

From Concern to Action

Can Highlighting the Dangers of Polarization Increase Citizens' Willingness to Intervene?
Evidence from Combined Experiments in Brazil

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2026

Outline

- 1 Motivation
- 2 Baseline Data
- 3 Survey Experiment Design
- 4 Hypotheses
- 5 Results: Voter Survey
- 6 Field Experiment: Elite Candidates
- 7 Conclusion

The Problem: Polarization in Contemporary Democracies

- Affective polarization has risen sharply across democracies — citizens increasingly **dislike** and **distrust** the other side

The Puzzle

People are aware of polarization's costs — yet **behavioral change remains elusive**.

Can *framing* those costs trigger action?

Our Approach

Two parallel experiments targeting **both** the supply (elites) and demand (citizens) sides simultaneously.

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- Brazil is a key case — one of the world's most polarized electorates after 2018

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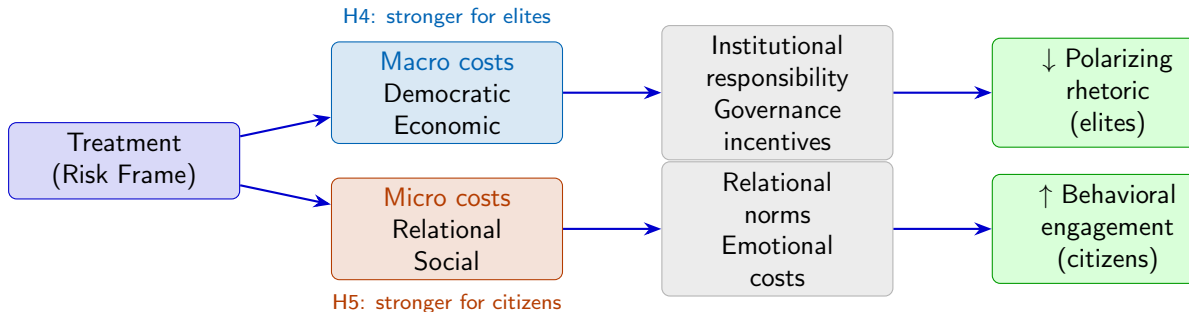
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Theoretical Framework



Key insight: behavioral change may occur *without* attitudinal depolarization (H7)

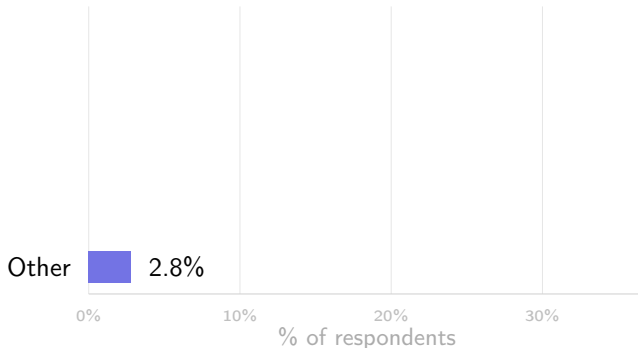
Why Brazil?

- 2022 election produced record-high polarization between PT and anti-PT camps
- Presidential race ongoing: Lula vs. Flávio Bolsonaro likely second round
- WhatsApp is the primary arena for political conflict among ordinary citizens
- Redes Cordiais — established NGO working on online conflict de-escalation

Why this moment?

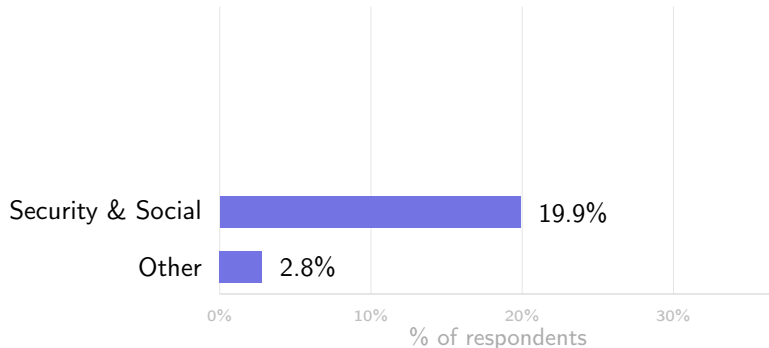
- Campaign period: elites actively calibrating rhetoric
- Citizens exposed to heavy political content
- Meta ad infrastructure enables direct elite targeting at scale
- 5-wave panel tracks behavioral decay over time

What Brazilians See as the Country's Biggest Problem



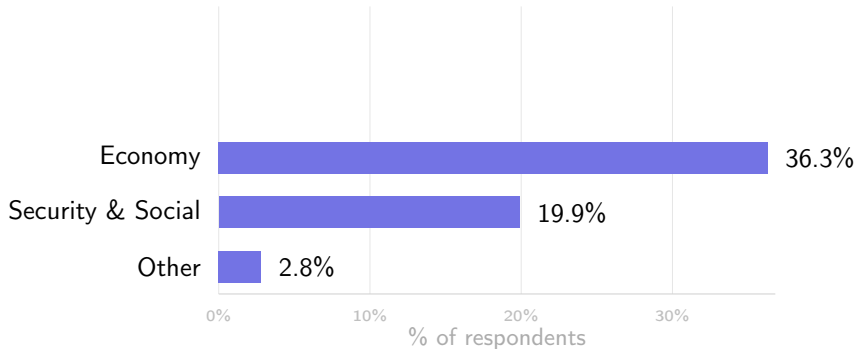
Note: Weighted baseline survey, Wave 1, $N \approx 5,900$. Economy includes unemployment, inflation, wages, inequality, taxes, growth. Security & Social includes violence, poverty, health, education, environment, sanitation.

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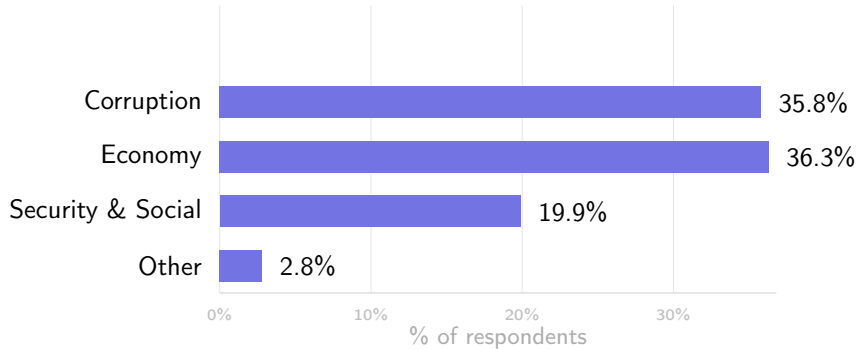
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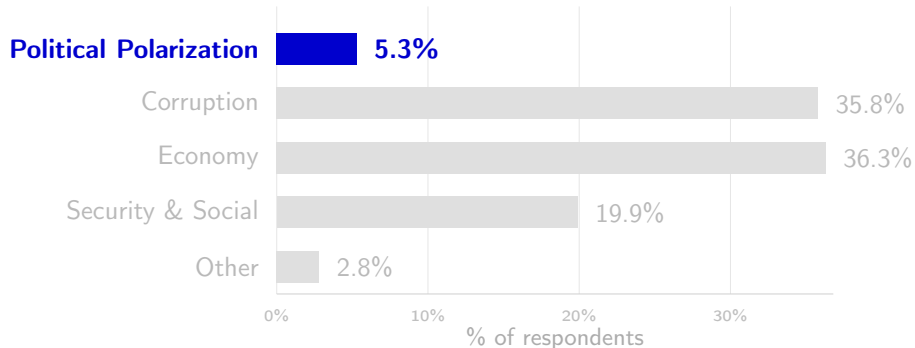
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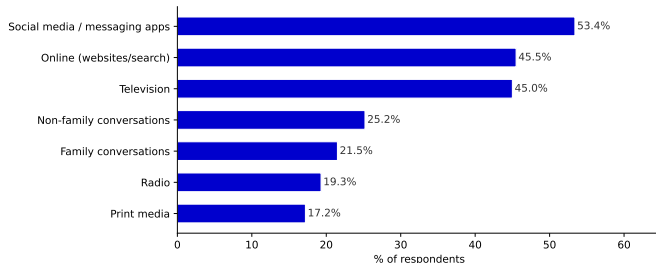
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How Brazilians Get Political News

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Key finding

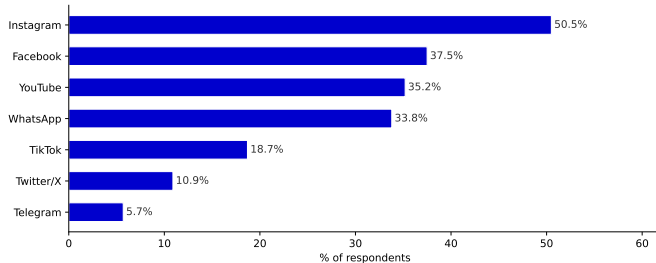
Social media and messaging apps are the dominant source of political news (53%), surpassing television and online search.

Implication

WhatsApp groups are the primary arena for political conflict — making them the right target for citizen-level interventions.

Platforms for Political Content

Platforms Where Political Content Was Received (Last Week)



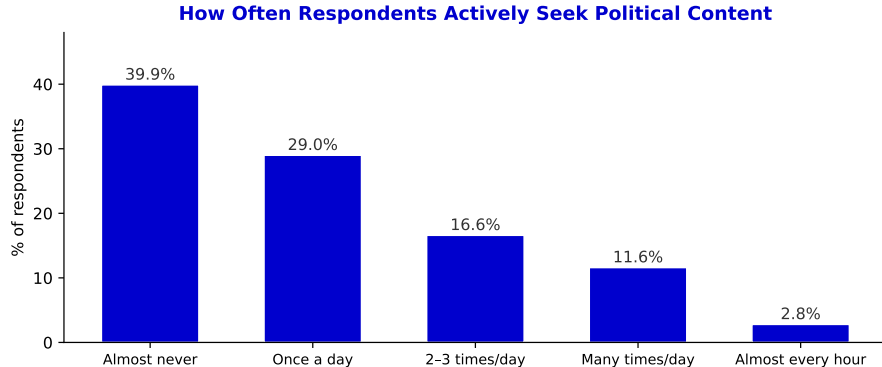
Instagram leads (50.5%), followed by Facebook (37.5%) and WhatsApp (33.8%).

Twitter/X (10.9%) and Telegram (5.7%) remain niche.

Design relevance

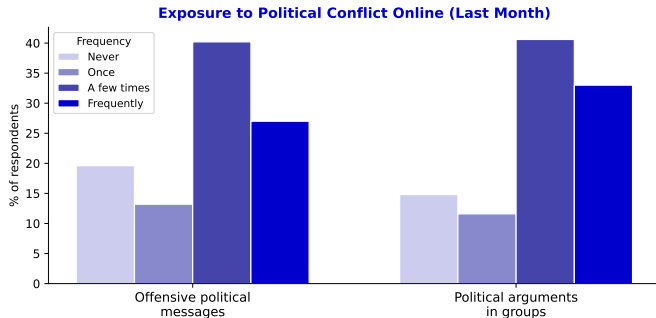
Instagram + Facebook coverage justifies Meta ad targeting for the elite experiment.

Frequency of Active Political Content Seeking



Nearly 70% actively seek political content at least once a day. High political engagement → high treatment reachability.

Exposure to Online Political Conflict



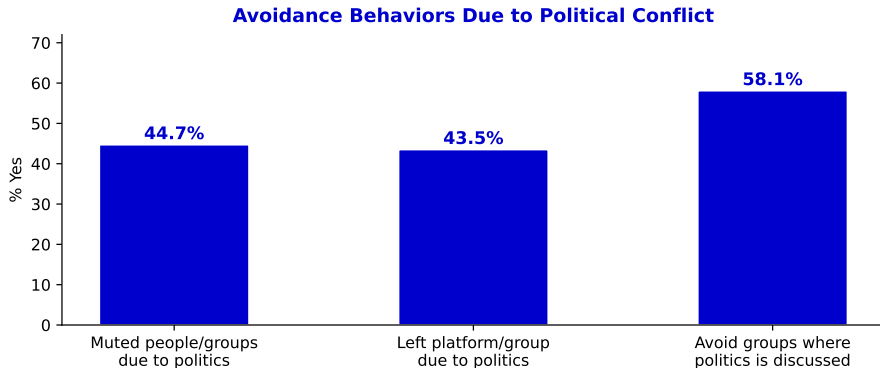
Conflict is frequent:

- 67% saw offensive political messages *a few times or frequently*
- 74% witnessed political arguments in groups at that level

Motivation

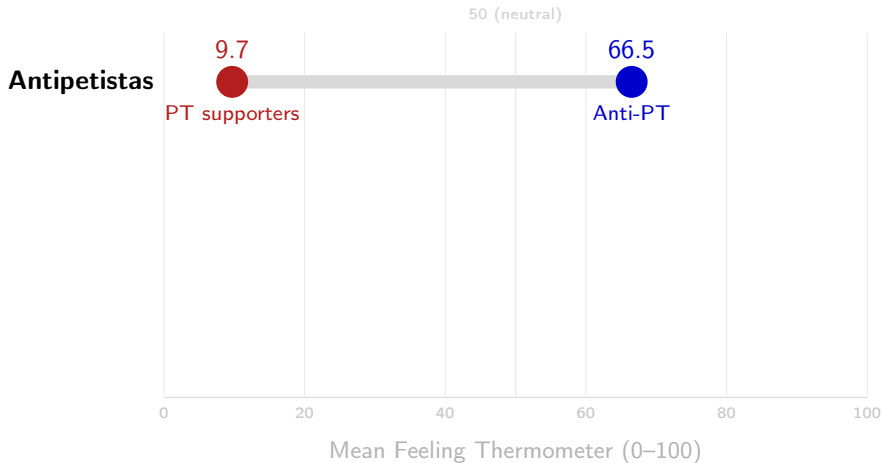
The problem is not latent — it is actively experienced. Concern about polarization is grounded in everyday reality.

Avoidance Behaviors Due to Political Conflict



Majorities have taken active steps to disengage from political conflict online. This avoidance — rather than engagement — is the default response our intervention aims to change.

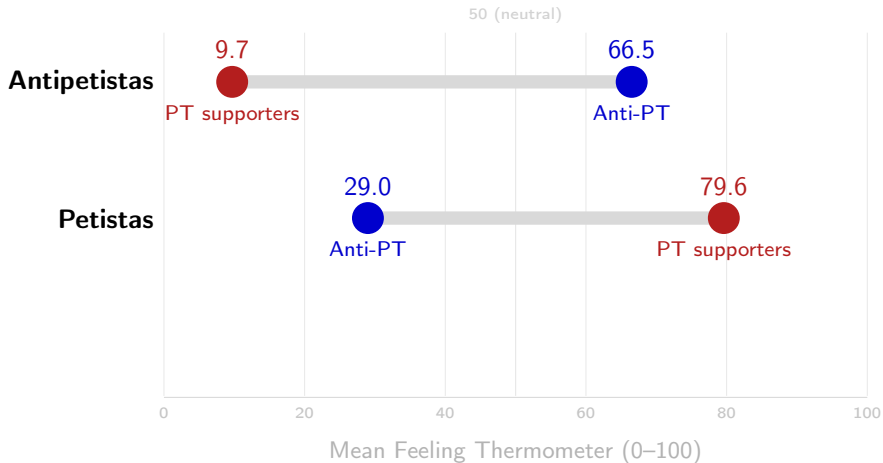
Affective Polarization: In-group vs. Out-group Thermometers



Note: Petistas = PT as favourite party ($n \approx 1,374$); Antipetistas = PT as least favourite ($n \approx 2,122$);

Non-partisans = all others.

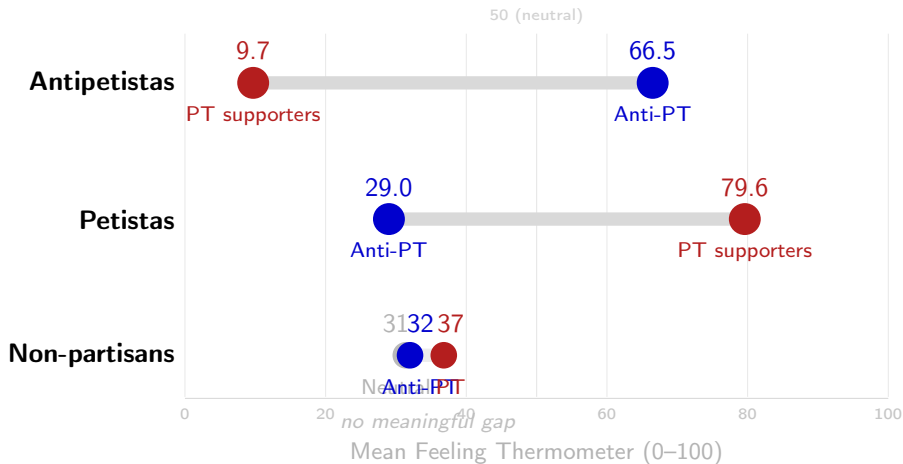
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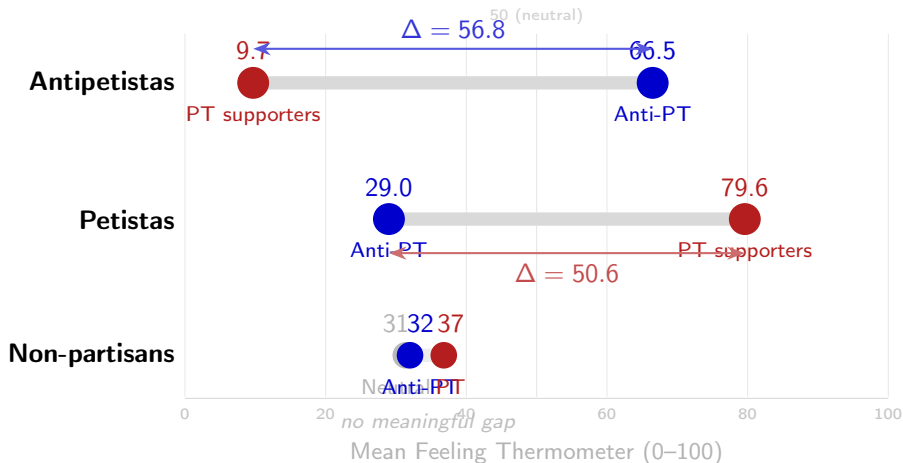
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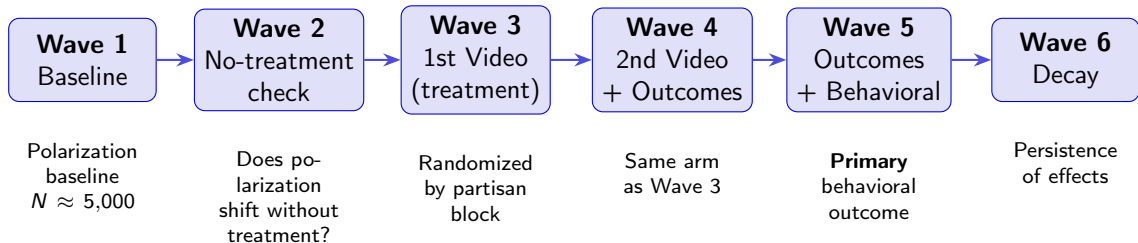
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Survey Experiment: Five-Wave Panel



Randomization: block-randomized by partisan group (PT supporters / Anti-PT / Neutral)

Retention incentive: lottery of 3 prizes of 1,000 Korus for panelists completing all waves

Wave 2 has no treatment — it tests whether polarization or issue priorities shift naturally during the campaign.

Treatment Arms: Four Informational Frames

Macro Frames

Democratic Deterioration

Polarization undermines electoral trust, weakens institutions, reduces acceptance of outcomes.

Economic Deterioration

Polarization increases uncertainty, discourages investment, generates gridlock, slows growth.

Micro Frames

Social Conflict

Polarization increases everyday hostility, normalizes aggression, reduces social trust.

Family Conflict

Polarization damages family relationships, causes estrangement and lasting relational harm.

Control

No informational frame; outcome measurement only

Note: Identical content across survey and field experiments.



Democratic Deterioration — Treatment Video

[Insert final video here]



Economic Deterioration — Treatment Video

[Insert final video here]



Social Conflict — Treatment Video

[Insert final video here]



Family Conflict — Treatment Video

[Insert final video here]

Primary Behavioral Outcomes

Primary: Seminar Enrollment

After treatment, respondents are offered free enrollment in a **1-hour online seminar** organized by *Redes Cordiais*:

- Practical strategies for polarizing content
- Responding to misinformation

Enrollment click = primary outcome

Secondary: Manual Download

Respondents are offered a downloadable **practical manual** with tips for managing political conflict in WhatsApp groups.

Download click = secondary behavioral outcome

Why behavioral?

Both outcomes require active choice, not just stated willingness. Low cost & low social desirability bias.

Secondary Outcomes and Mechanisms

Secondary outcomes (voters)

- Stated willingness to intervene in WhatsApp conflicts
- Self-reported corrective behavior (subsequent waves)
- Support for democratic norms / election acceptance
- Affective thermometers (H7 “should not move”)

Mechanisms

- Perceived costs of polarization (macro index, micro index)
- Perceived efficacy of intervention

Placebo / “Should not move”

- Partisan compromise attitudes
- Anti-democratic norm trade-offs (e.g., bypassing courts)
- Affective polarization thermometers

H7 test

If behavioral outcomes move *without* thermometers moving, we confirm action $\neq$ attitude change.

Pre-Registered Hypotheses

-
- H1** **Manipulation check:** Each treatment increases perceived costs of polarization in its corresponding domain (macro vs. micro).
-
- H2** Exposure to any treatment **reduces polarizing rhetoric** among candidates relative to control.
- H3** Exposure to any treatment **increases behavioral engagement** among voters relative to control.
-
- H4** **Macro frames** produce larger effects among **candidates** than micro frames.
- H5** **Micro frames** produce larger effects among **voters** than macro frames.
-
- H6** Treatment effects are **mediated** by increased perceived costs and perceived efficacy.

Field Experiment: Targeting Political Elites

Population & Scale

- ~10,000 candidates for Federal and State Deputy
- Identified via official electoral records (TSE)
- Verified public Meta accounts (Facebook & Instagram)
- **Over 25,000 candidate emails extracted** from official records

Delivery

- Paid Meta advertisements shown in candidates' own social media environments
- Direct email campaign with treatment videos
- Individual-level randomization (5 arms)

Outcome Measurement

Polarizing rhetoric in public posts during campaign period, measured via **supervised text classification**:

- Delegitimizing opponents
- Framing rivals as threats
- Inflammatory language

Secondary

Depolarizing cues (civility, bridge-building) and democratic norm compliance

Partnership with Redes Cordiais

Who they are

- Leading Brazilian NGO focused on online conflict de-escalation
- Experience training citizens to respond to polarizing content
- Recognized credibility across political groups

Role in the study

- Co-host of the 1-hour intervention seminar (primary behavioral outcome)
- Provide the practical manual for WhatsApp conflict
- Lend legitimacy to the intervention materials

Why this partnership matters

The behavioral outcome is not hypothetical — enrollment links to a **real, existing program**. This eliminates demand effects and ensures the intervention has downstream real-world impact beyond the experiment.

Agreement status

Formal agreement with Redes Cordiais in place for seminar delivery and content collaboration.

Elite Experiment: Showing Voters Dislike Polarization

The mechanism for elites

- Candidates face electoral incentives
- Treatment reveals a **credible signal**: voters are concerned about polarization's costs
- Provides reputational & governance rationale to moderate rhetoric

Campaign channels

- ① Instagram & Facebook paid ads (Meta targeting by candidate account)
- ② Direct email with treatment videos to 25,000+ candidate emails
- ③ Content mirrors the four informational frames used in the survey experiment

Key message to elites

"Brazilian voters across the spectrum are concerned about how polarization harms [democracy / the economy / families / communities]. Your rhetoric affects these outcomes."

Identification advantage

Simultaneous elite + citizen intervention allows testing whether **supply and demand changes reinforce each other**.

What we are doing

- ① 5-wave panel survey experiment with $N \approx 5,000$ Brazilian voters
- ② Field experiment with $\sim 10,000$ candidates for Federal and State Deputy
- ③ Four informational frames (macro: democratic, economic; micro: social, family conflict)
- ④ Behavioral primary outcomes (seminar enrollment, manual download)

Why it matters

- Tests whether *framing* polarization costs is enough to trigger action — without requiring attitude change
- First study to intervene simultaneously on both elites and citizens using identical frames
- Real-world partnership with Redes Cordiais ensures external validity
- Results speak to the possibility of **behavioral depolarization** even in highly divided polities

Core contribution